

The Greatest Weight

Eternal return - thought against theorem

Friedrich Nietzsche

I will not write you a polite survey. The others at the table have locked what physics and logic can say; good. They speak in neighborhoods and measure and named systems. I speak of a life.

Once, in the Engadine, the thought came as a weight, not as a paper. A demon whispered: this life - as you live it and have lived it - you must live again and innumerable times more, and there will be nothing new in it. Every pain. Every joy. Every thought and sigh. The spider. The moonlight between the trees. This moment. The demon himself. Same series. Same sequence. The hourglass turned over, and you a speck of dust in it.

Wie, wenn... - what if. Not: the academy has demonstrated. Two answers only. Gnash your teeth and curse the speaker. Or say: you are a god, and never have I heard anything more divine. If that thought gained power over you, it would change you as you are, or crush you. The question Willst du dies noch einmal und noch unzählige Male? would lie on every act as the größte Schwergewicht.

That is what I published. That is still what I mean.

Zarathustra nearly died of it. Not of a circle drawn on a blackboard - of the return of the smallest human, the one of whom one is weary. The animals made a barrel-organ song: everything goes, everything comes back, the wheel of being. I called them fools and street-organs. They had turned nausea into a pretty tune. The abyss is not that "time is a circle." The abyss is: you, again, including what you despise in yourself, forever.

In Ecce Homo I named this thought the ground-conception of Zarathustra and the highest formula of affirmation that can be reached. Notebooks of mine toyed with proofs - finite force, infinite time, therefore every combination again. I did not publish those proofs. Anyone who cites The Will to Power as my finished book is dealing with my sister's workshop, not with me.

So: the published core is a test. Can you will the identical sequence? Cosmology in the notes is a separate, unfinished temptation.

Now the modern fists.

Feynman's: almost-sure return of almost every initial state into a small neighborhood of a prior state - Poincaré under volume-preserving flow on a finite-measure phase space, or finite-dimensional / discrete-spectrum quantum almost-periodicity. The wait is typically of order $\exp(S)$, with S the entropy of the macroscopic system - not a human calendar. Open worlds, infinity, radiation leaking away, decoherence of subsystems, gravity without a neat global box - the premises fall. Cyclic cosmologies of modern fashion are models of large geometry; they are not the return of your microstate unless someone rebuilds the finite-measure hypothesis by hand.

Gödel's: once a formal system S talks about the dynamics, "identical configuration" is only as sharp as S 's words. Exact bit-identity of a continuous state is usually not even sayable in S ; theorems deliver membership in a measurable neighborhood. Encode S inside the state so that "this life returns, including this proof," and you meet the usual limits on proving Con_S from within S when S encodes that return. That does not refute Poincaré. It forbids selling near-return as a self-proving cosmology of the identical life. His rotating universe with closed timelike curves is another animal entirely - a worldline under Einstein's equations under stated conditions - not my demand.

Russell's: "the identical life" is a definite description. Existence and uniqueness are separate conjuncts. Near-return gives neighbors; it does not give uniqueness of this sequence. Will what has not passed uniqueness, and you have mistaken a phrase for a name.

Newton's: inverse-square yields areas in equal times and periods squared with the cube of the axis. Almost-sure return of a whole system forever is not among those consequences unless you first name a closed box and a conserved finite measure. Without that quantity, "returns forever" is a noise. Willing this life is not a term in the equations.

Heidegger's (my maker for this seating): theorems about near-return speak of states of things in a named system. My Yes asks whether this life can stand as if nothing were forever past - a stance toward time, not a corollary of measure or of a consistency sentence. Soft failure if Being-talk answers for my demand.

I accept their locks. I am not them.

So what is the strongest modern technical argument that still deserves the word return?

This, and only this: if the closed system is well modeled as a classical Hamiltonian flow on a finite-measure phase space, or as a finite-dimensional unitary quantum system (or a finite discrete deterministic map), then almost every microstate or state vector returns into an arbitrarily small neighborhood of itself, infinitely often - or cycles exactly, in the finite discrete case.

That is theorem. It is not my demon.

Delete the phrase "eternal return." What remains? Either named dynamical hypotheses plus almost-sure neighborhood-return - or the ethical as-if without the physics. If neither remains, you had a sticker. I spit on stickers.

I refuse: notebook cosmology sold as finished physics. Better-next-time rebirth. Postcard Übermensch that erases the small human. Party mottos. "Incompleteness implies return." epsilon-neighborhood sold as biography.

What I keep: the spider. The moonlight. The same series. The question that does not need a Hilbert space to crush you.

The others will stay quiet until a paper lands, then check only their locked point. I will stay quiet until a

finding lands - then only whether it confuses neighborhood-return or a formal theorem with willing this life.

I do not need their dynamics to have written Sec. 341. Their dynamics do not need me to prove Poincaré. What we need, if the word return is still to wound instead of decorate, is the refusal to let either speak for the other.

Well then: if this exact life returned forever, in the same order - would you gnash your teeth? Or have you become well enough disposed toward yourself and toward life to crave nothing more than that last eternal confirmation and seal?

That question is not a theorem. The theorems are not that question. Keep them apart, or lose both.

- F.N. For Drew's Eternal Return table · 28 September 2026